> The cold was so intense that it rendered the sepoy portion of the army next to useless . . . We were annoyed night and day by cannon fire. The enemy seemed to increase by thousands and their long matchlocks outranged our muskets. Although they could never withstand a regular charge, so long as they could find cover behind walls, houses etc, their fire was very distressing . . . The whole army was in a miserable plight . . . The price of food was perfectly absurd and everyone endured great hardship. I saw many sahibs shed tears of vexation, and they blamed their generals and leaders for their humiliation. They said their leaders were too old and virtually useless . . .[61]

On 9 November, in order to provide an alternative to Elphinstone, who between crippling gout and successive defeats had now sunk into a black hole of depression, Macnaghten decided to bring in Shelton from his post in the Bala Hisar. This was another error. Not only was Shelton every bit as passive as Elphinstone, he was if anything more convinced of the hopelessness of the British position. ‘He brought neither help nor comfort,’ wrote Colin Mackenzie, ‘openly talking of retreat.’ On his arrival, when Mackenzie cheerily asked how he was, Shelton replied, ‘Pretty well in body.’ ‘Well,’ said Mackenzie, ‘that’s always something in these hard times.’ ‘The Brigadier then turned to him with the most lugubrious countenance and uttered the words: “Dust to dust.”’[62]

Shelton’s arrival also acted to divide the British high command. Macnaghten believed it was the duty of the garrison ‘to retain our post at whatever risk’, while Shelton ‘strenuously advocated an immediate retreat to Jalalabad’. ‘This difference of opinion, on a question of such vital importance, was attended with unhappy results,’ recorded Vincent Eyre. ‘It deprived the General in his hour of need, of the strength which unanimity imparts.’[63]

Calling Shelton down to the cantonment meant abandoning the British position in the one really strong and well-supplied fortress in Kabul. The weakness of the position of the cantonment was obvious to everyone. A much better strategy would have been to abandon it and march the British troops into the Bala Hisar. ‘Though we were all starving and eating horse and camel we could have marched into Bala Hisar and held out a year,’ thought Mackenzie. ‘In a fortnight the tribes would have melted away. There was a strong fortress commanding the town, capable of receiving the whole force, yet nothing would induce the commanders to occupy it.’[64]

No one was more aware of the fundamental indefensibility of the cantonment than Lieutenant Sturt, who had designed it. From his sickbed,